

Australia Chair Daily Brief

AUSTRALIA · NEW ZEALAND · THE PACIFIC ISLANDS

Tuesday, September 8, 2026

RE: Solomon Islands accuses Australia of interference · Albanese unveils Digital Duty of Care · Wong preps Israel sanctions, no trade ban · NZ military seeks deeper Australia ties · PIF Koror wrap lands

ASX 200 **8,897** -0.91% AUD/USD **0.7226** +0.87% NZX 50 **13,774** -1.13% NZD/USD **0.5860** +0.15%
BRENT **99.32** +3.86%

TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Solomon Islands' Opposition and former prime minister Manasseh Sogavare accused Australia of interfering in domestic politics after a leaked text message surfaced during treaty negotiations, days before Canberra finalises a billion-dollar package deal with Honiara.
- 2 Albanese unveiled draft Digital Duty of Care legislation letting Australians switch off social media algorithms, with fines above \$100 million for platforms that fail to curb foreseeable harms, drawing censorship accusations from Angus Taylor.
- 3 New Zealand's military is seeking deeper operational ties with Australia, Reuters reported, as an RNZAF P-8A Poseidon and crew join the multinational Pacific Vanguard exercise around Guam.

TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Solomon Islands accuses Australia of interference over leaked treaty text

Former Solomon Islands prime minister Manasseh Sogavare said he fears Australia has meddled in his nation's internal politics after a leaked text message between the Australian High Commission and deputy prime minister Francis Sade surfaced. The Opposition said the message appeared to use Australian funding to influence a no-confidence motion against Prime Minister Matthew Wale, which was withdrawn just as Australia agreed in principle to a billion-dollar treaty package. Sade rejected the claims, calling the text an update on successful negotiations that should not be used as political ammunition.

So what: The row lands as Australia prepares to sign its next wide-ranging Pacific security treaty, testing Canberra's pitch as Solomon Islands' security partner of choice.

Pattern: Lowy Institute research fellow Oliver Nobetau said every broad bilateral agreement signed in the past 12 months has carried language on denying strategic access to third parties.

per SMH Federal Politics (Matthew Knott): "'Deeply concerned': Former Solomons leader accuses Australia of foreign interference" · also ABC Politics: "Solomon Islands Opposition accuses Australia of foreign interference"

AU-POLITICS

Albanese unveils Digital Duty of Care, opt-out algorithm rules

Prime Minister Anthony Albanese announced draft Digital Duty of Care legislation that would let Australians opt out of social media algorithms in favour of a "following feed," building on the existing under-16 social media ban. Platforms that fail to reduce foreseeable harms would face fines of more than \$100 million. Opposition Leader Angus Taylor and other Coalition figures raised censorship concerns, and Greens senator Sarah Hanson-Young said users must have "genuine choice" about content in their feeds.

So what: The bill would make Australia one of the most aggressive platform regulators among close US allies, arriving alongside higher tax bills for American tech companies.

per AFR: "Albanese announces new algorithm rules, shrugs off Trump" · also NYT: "Australian Social Media Users Could Get Power to Switch Off Algorithms"

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Wong prepares new Israel sanctions, rules out trade ban

Foreign Minister Penny Wong is preparing new sanctions against Israel but has ruled out a trade ban, after Britain announced curbs on economic activity with Israeli settlements. Former Labor minister Ed Husic called the British plan a "seismic movement by one of our close allies." Israel's ambassador warned Canberra that broad sanctions on settlements would be "a deep mistake," The Australian reported.

So what: Canberra's calibration will determine whether Australia joins the settlement-goods import ban now adopted by Britain, France and Canada.

per SMH Federal Politics (Matthew Knott): "Penny Wong prepares new sanctions against Israel but no trade ban" · also The Australian: "Israel warns Canberra not to follow UK sanctions lead"

OVERNIGHT

NZ-DEFENSE · REUTERS

New Zealand military seeks deeper operational ties with Australia

New Zealand's military is seeking deeper operational ties with Australia, Reuters reported. The wire's report carried no further detail in today's collection. Trans-Tasman integration has been a recurring theme of New Zealand defence planning under the National-ACT-NZ First coalition, whose general election falls on November 7.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Foreign network deepfakes dozens of Australian politicians

Reset Tech has tracked more than 200 Facebook pages impersonating Anthony Albanese, Angus Taylor, Pauline Hanson and other figures over eight months, linking the campaign to an influencer business in Sri Lanka. Roughly 10 percent of the pages had been monetised by Facebook, letting operators profit directly. Chief research officer Rys Farthing said "this isn't foreign interference as we traditionally think of it."

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY · RNZ PACIFIC

Australia releases terms of Nauru deportation deal

Australia has released the agreement to deport more than 350 refugees and asylum seekers, the "NZYQ cohort," to Naoero, after resisting disclosure for more than a year. Greens senator David Shoebridge said the release "only scratches the surface" and that the government continues to resist producing a separate financial

memorandum. Home Affairs Minister Tony Burke said in August 2025 the deal gave Naoero AU\$2.5 billion over thirty years.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Thawley warns Japan-China is the ultimate flashpoint from Xi's Taiwan ambitions

Former senior diplomat Michael Thawley warned that a Japan-China clash arising from Xi Jinping's ambitions toward Taiwan is the region's ultimate security flashpoint, The Australian reported. No further detail of his remarks was available in today's report.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Report finds voters losing patience with the two-party system

The Centre for Policy Development's annual Purpose of Government Pulse found a clear majority of Australian voters want greater say in setting national policy priorities, with many turning to independents and minor parties such as One Nation. The centre-left think tank warned that declining faith in politicians puts trust in democracy at "profound risk."

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY · ABC NEWS

Student visa refusal rate hits decade high

Department of Home Affairs data shows student visa refusals climbed from 7.9 percent in June 2016 to 24.2 percent in June this year. More than 51 percent of applications from Nepal were rejected in 2025-2026 and more than 40 percent from India, against 5.8 percent for China.

PACIFIC WIRE

KIRIBATI · ABC PACIFIC

More than 300 WWII munitions destroyed on Betio Island

Operation Pakodua destroyed more than 300 unexploded ordnance on Betio Island over the weekend, the site of the 76-hour Battle of Tarawa in which more than 6,000 soldiers died. NZDF Lieutenant Colonel Cameron Wright said the operation, planned over years with the New Zealand Defence Force, also trained local authorities, with an RNZAF C-130J flying in equipment.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · RADIO FREE ASIA

Honiara's domestic squabbles could frustrate diplomatic engagement

Radio Free Asia reported that domestic political manoeuvring in Solomon Islands, following the withdrawal of the no-confidence motion, could frustrate the country's diplomatic engagement. The report follows Prime Minister Matthew Wale's suspension of parliament after a leadership rebellion collapsed.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Bougainville's Toroama under scrutiny over wife's transplant

Bougainville President Ishmael Toroama faces scrutiny over his wife's transplant, Islands Business reported, as the autonomous region approaches its independence goal almost forty years after descending into civil war. Separately, PACNEWS reported Pacific leaders being urged to keep the Bougainville issue internal.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

Documentary warns of Frieda River mine impact on Sepik

If approved, the Frieda River copper and gold mine would be one of Papua New Guinea's biggest, and community groups fear its waste could devastate the Sepik River basin, which sustains about half a million people. The documentary "Sukundimi Walks Before Me" follows activist Emmanuel Peni.

TONGA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Tonga Met chief urges media to turn warnings into action

Pacific media have been urged to convert weather and climate information into knowledge, and warnings into action, as the region enters the tropical cyclone season. PACNEWS separately reported forecasts that El Nino

impacts on the Pacific will last well into 2027.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

PALM workers honoured for 2022 Lismore flood rescues

Fijian workers who helped rescue residents and distribute emergency supplies during the 2022 Lismore floods have been recognised for their service. Islands Business separately reported that little is publicly known about how the welfare support system underpinning the Pacific Australia Labour Mobility scheme actually works.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Fiji watchdog warns foreign money could influence political parties

PACNEWS reported that Fiji's Centre for Democracy and Development warned foreign money could influence political parties, and that Fiji's HIV crisis is spreading faster than the health system can manage. The same bulletin flagged the new Pacific Islands Forum partner model facing its first test in New Zealand.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-DEFENSE · ISLANDS BUSINESS

RNZAF P-8A joins Pacific Vanguard exercise around Guam

A Royal New Zealand Air Force P-8A Poseidon and its crew are taking part in the multinational Pacific Vanguard warfare exercise around Guam. The deployment puts New Zealand's newest maritime patrol aircraft into a US-hosted exercise in the northern Pacific.

NZ-POLITICS · REUTERS

New Zealand to allow wealthy migrants to build rental housing

New Zealand will allow wealthy migrants to build rental housing, Reuters reported. The change extends the coalition's investor migration settings into residential construction two months before the November 7 general election.

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · BEEHIVE.GOV.T.NZ

Government confirms continued support to Ukraine

The New Zealand government announced it will continue its support to Ukraine, according to a Beehive release. The statement extends a commitment maintained across the National-ACT-NZ First coalition's term.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

SOLOMON ISLANDS · RECOGNITION SWITCH · ABC NEWS

ABC questions value for money in Australia's Solomon Islands spending

About a dozen Australian government billboards dominate prime positions in Honiara, proclaiming in English and Solomon Islands pijin that Australia is the "Nambawan patna long sekiuriti," or number one security partner. The ABC reports the billboards proliferated after the 2019 switch of diplomatic recognition to Beijing, and asks whether billions in spending has bought results as Canberra prepares another billion-dollar treaty.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Albanese makes "no apologies" for \$6 million grant

Albanese defended a \$6 million grant and said the ABC needed to "do better" after allegedly ignoring context from his media office. Crossbench MPs called for an overhaul of a grant system they describe as "pork

barrelling by design," and Nationals senator Bridget McKenzie said the program appeared to be "invite only."

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

One Nation's Victorian leader admits past drug use

Warren Pickering, One Nation's Victorian leader and candidate for Pakenham, admitted using speed, ecstasy and marijuana in his twenties after his former partner spoke to The Australian. The 43-year-old said he stopped before joining the Australian Defence Force at 28 and disclosed the history when he applied.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

High Court hears challenge to post-Bondi hate laws

The High Court is hearing a challenge to Australia's post-Bondi anti-hate laws brought by the banned neo-Nazi group White Australia, which brands the laws authoritarian, The Australian reported.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

RBA's Hauser says inflation too high, rates may need to rise

Reserve Bank deputy governor Andrew Hauser said in a rare television interview that the economy is running stronger than expected, forcing the bank to weigh rate rises, and that "people are furious about inflation." Assistant governor Sarah Hunter said the housing downturn is hitting related sectors but rejected a developer's recession warning.

AU-DEFENSE · THE AUSTRALIAN

Second bid lands for Austal USA, valued above \$1.73 billion

A second bid has landed for Austal USA, valuing the shipbuilder's American arm at more than \$1.73 billion, The Australian reported. Austal builds vessels for the US Navy and is a supplier in Australia's naval shipbuilding base.

AU-POLITICS · AFR

Australia slides in international maths and reading rankings

More than half of Australian 15-year-olds did not meet the national proficiency standard in maths, according to new PISA results that put China and Singapore in the lead. Federal education minister Jason Clare said the primary school maths curriculum will be overhauled.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

COMMUNIQUE · PACIFIC MEDIA NETWORK

New Pacific Islands Forum partner model set for first test in New Zealand

The two-tier dialogue partner model agreed at the 55th Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting will face its first test in New Zealand, Pacific Media Network reported. The Forum chair passed to Palau President Surangel Whipps Jr at the Koror meeting.

CALENDAR WATCH

7 Nov 2026

New Zealand general election, advance voting from October 26

Determines whether the National-ACT-NZ First coalition continues the defence and Pacific settings now being deepened with Australia.

signing expected
in coming days
2026

Australia-Solomon Islands billion-dollar treaty package

Australia has agreed in principle and the Opposition in Honiara is contesting the process that produced it.

first test to be
hosted in New
Zealand 2026

First application of the Forum's new two-tier dialogue partner model

Sets the precedent for how China, the United States and Taiwan engage Forum meetings.

expected within
two months 2026

Independent review of the South Australian Electoral Commission's 2026 election handling

Will document the staffing failures reported at polling booths on state election day.

annual, venue
alternates 2026

AUSMIN

The forum where a larger US military presence on Australian soil, flagged by Marles and Hegseth, would be formalised.

ALSO TODAY

LOWY INTERPRETER

Minerals diplomacy is Australia's opening in Africa

Mining expertise gives Australia a chance to capitalise on African demand for fairer mineral deals, the Interpreter argues.

ASPI STRATEGIST

Electrification of Australian mining is crucial for making the industry energy secure

The diesel price shock from the 2026 Iran crisis makes the case for electrifying Australian mining, the Strategist argues, urging the industry to stop relying on imported diesel.

SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Chalmers to release figures showing age pension costs falling

Treasurer Jim Chalmers will publish new figures showing the age pension's cost to the budget will fall as superannuation grows, amid the political fight over One Nation's early-access proposal. Australia's superannuation system holds \$4.4 trillion.

PACIFIC MEDIA NETWORK

Is an empty seat a silent seat? What Palau told us about Pacific unity

Pacific Media Network examines what the leaders absent from the Koror summit signalled about Forum unity, following the five-leader no-show reported last week.